Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Shelley's "Ozymandias" and Sa'di's [A Vision of Sultan Mahmud]

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

diction (word choice),
imagery,
irony,
simile,
tone (word choice),
explicit moral statement (Sa'di), and
implicit moral statement (Shelley).

The prompt asks the contestant to address the poems' common theme, which involves a recognition that the power as well as the glory (empire in the case of Ozymandias; reputation in the case of Nushirvan) acquired during a person's time on earth are indeed as fleeting as any material goods.

The contestant's approach might be a simplistic comparison of the poems as vehicles to carry the theme, or the approach might recognize the difference between a Western traveler's physical journey to a point where the past speaks to the present (coincidentally, a geographic point in the East) and in the case of Mahmud's vision, a journey that is not actually physical but does involve specific imagery of the physical body's "surrender to the earth"—the past, in Mahmud's vision being less remote and the geography more immediate.

Additionally, a more sophisticated contrast (though generalized) might be drawn between the Westerner's need for an empirical, perhaps literal, vehicle for the transitory nature of man's endeavors (what we build falls down) and the Easterner's appreciation of the parable—the less literal (a dream vision sufficing).

Optimism pervades both poems' messages: Shelley's is couched in the irony that feared strength suffers demise even though it speaks the strength of endurance ("Look on my works, ye mighty, and despair"), and Sa'di's optimism is proffered as a *raison d'être*: live a good life ("Do good, O man, and consider life as a good fortune").